

Summary: Do we still need PMs?

Narrative Summary

The video discusses the disproportionate impact of Artificial Intelligence (AI) on different roles within tech teams, particularly highlighting how engineering benefits significantly more than product managers (PMs) and designers. While AI provides increased leverage across the board, engineers are currently experiencing a two to three times boost in productivity due to tools like Claude code. This creates a significant imbalance in traditional team structures.

Using a typical team example of five engineers, one designer, and one PM, the speaker illustrates how AI effectively multiplies the engineering output, making that group equivalent to 10-15 engineers. Although PMs and designers also gain leverage from AI, their roles do not scale at the same rate. Consequently, the existing PMs and designers find themselves managing an effectively much larger and more productive engineering force without a corresponding increase in their own numbers or support.

This scenario leads to PM and design roles feeling “squeezed.” They are grappling with the increased scope and complexity of coordinating and guiding a significantly amplified engineering capacity. The implication is that despite the initial question, the enhanced productivity from AI suggests a future need for a substantial increase in PMs to adequately support and leverage the accelerated engineering output, rather than diminishing their necessity.

Key Points

- AI significantly boosts engineering leverage, increasing productivity by 2-3 times.
- PMs and designers also gain leverage from AI, but to a lesser extent than engineers.
- This creates an imbalance where PMs and designers are now managing an effectively much larger engineering group.
- A typical team of five engineers can effectively become 10-15 engineers in terms of output due to AI.
- PM and design roles are feeling “squeezed” due to the increased workload and responsibility without proportional growth.
- The situation suggests a potential future need to hire “a ton more PMs” to match the amplified engineering capacity.

Notable Quotes

- “PM and design is just squeezed. It’s just absolutely squeezed.” (0:34)